

SOC201: INTRODUCTION TO SOCIOLOGY



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Detailed Licensing

Licensing

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

1: Getting Started- What is Sociology?

Welcome to Introduction to Sociology

In this course, you'll journey into the world of sociology—the systematic study of society and human interaction. We'll start by exploring what sociology is as a social science, diving into the research methods sociologists use to examine the social world. You'll then get acquainted with the foundational theories of Western sociology and explore non-Western perspectives that offer alternative insights.

From there, we'll focus on core areas that shape our understanding of society, including:

- **Culture**
- **Crime & Deviance**, with both individualistic and sociological perspectives
- **Social Stratification**, exploring class and inequality
- **Gender Studies**
- **Race & Ethnicity**

Module 1: Getting Oriented

In this opening module, you'll:

1. Learn and define essential sociological terms.
2. Engage with key texts and readings.
3. Collaborate in small groups during class activities.
4. Explore the distinctions between social sciences and natural sciences through guided questions and discussions.

Let's embark on this exploration of society together—seeing how sociology illuminates the structures, interactions, and ideas that shape our lives.



Sociology is the systematic study of society and social interaction. The word “sociology” is derived from the Latin word *socius* (companion) and the Greek word *logos* (speech or reason). Sociology is the study of society, social behavior, and the structures that shape human interactions. By critically exploring patterns of social relationships, inequalities, and change, sociologists examine how individuals, groups, and institutions influence and are influenced by social forces, such as culture, education, politics, and economics. Sociologists use various research methods, including qualitative and quantitative approaches, to uncover the underlying social processes that govern our everyday experiences.

The sociologist Dorothy Smith (1926 –) defines *the social* as the “ongoing concerting and coordinating of individuals’ activities” (Smith, 1999). Aspects of social life never simply occur; they are organized processes. They can be the briefest of everyday interactions—walking past someone on the sidewalk or going to the store—or the largest and most enduring interactions—such as the billions of daily exchanges that constitute the circuits of global capitalism. Like a child just discovering the world, sociologists incessantly ask “why” about human behavior, especially that which seems to be taken for granted. Why in the US do we walk to the right on the sidewalk? What collective processes led to the decision that moving to the right rather than the left is normative?

Sociologists also look behind what is visible to uncover deeper and more complex relationships. Examining the coffee you drink in the morning can reveal a series of interactions, both local and global. Where are the coffee beans grown? Who picked the coffee beans? From where is coffee exported? To where is it imported? What cultural rituals involve coffee? Is coffee drinking gendered? These are the type of questions that point to the unique domain and puzzles that sociology seeks to explore and understand.



Have you ever paused and realized that *your* way of thinking and behaving isn't the *only* way? Maybe this shift happened:

- When you traveled and encountered a new culture
- While visiting a different neighborhood in your city
- Through reading a novel set in another world or listening to someone whose life is very different from yours

Consider the tiny things: we line up to pay at stores, eat cake with a fork but pizza with our hands—do these habits ever make you stop and wonder *why*?

That exact moment—when the familiar becomes strange—is when we begin to notice the invisible social rules that guide our daily behavior, also known as *social norms*. These norms are the unspoken expectations we learn from our culture—like shaking hands on meeting someone, standing in line, using chopsticks in some countries, or using our hands for pizza in others. They're the unwritten etiquette that shapes our interactions and makes social life largely predictable.

As we go further in this course, we'll explore how these norms form, vary across cultures, and influence the way we live, think, and relate to one another.

References:

Smith, D. E. (1999). *Writing the social: Critique, theory, and investigations*. University of Toronto Press.

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1.1: Readings

1) Read *What is Sociology* From the American Sociological Association website. This brief passage provides an overview on society and culture, how sociologists look at human behavior as patterned, and the concept of social structures and social institutions. As you read, think about the concepts of society and culture, the perspectives sociologists use to study the world around them, and the patterns of human behaviors.

What is Sociology?

Sociology is the study of social life, social change, and the social causes and consequences of human behavior. Sociologists investigate the structure of groups, organizations, and societies and how people interact within these contexts. Since all human behavior is social, the subject matter of sociology ranges from the intimate family to global communities; from deviance to organized crime; from religious traditions to state institutions; and from the divisions of race, gender and social class to the shared beliefs of a common culture.

2) Watch the video [Sociologists on Sociology](#) on Vimeo from June 2018. Sixteen sociologists speak about the impact of sociology. sixteen sociologists speak briefly to the need for and impact of their field.

“Sociologists on Sociology” is a primer on a discipline that studies many of the major issues confronting American society. As one respondent puts it: “So much of what is going on with our political climate and the rhetoric right now is all about talking about individual people or individual communities. The reality is, these are collective problems that have structural bases.”

2) Read [Invitation to Sociology](#) by Peter Berger (1929-2017) which discusses key points about the field of sociology including:

- **Sociology as a Lens:** Understand society through unique perspectives and patterns.
- **Freedom vs. Control:** Explore how individuals navigate societal rules and find moments of choice.
- **Society as Drama:** See life as a stage where people play roles within social structures.
- **Teaching Tool:** The book helps students question individualistic views of behavior.
- **Human Choice:** Highlights personal freedom and the ability to challenge societal norms.

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1.2: Getting Started--What is Sociology--Classroom Activity

In this classroom activity, you will interpret a quote and connect it to sociological ideas. You will share your ideas with the class. This activity will get you thinking about what it means to be in a society and how we can discuss human interaction. As you discuss your interpretation of the quote, think about the following ideas that connect to readings in this section:

- 1) Patterned social interactions
- 2) Social structures and institutions
- 3) Freedom vs. control or agency vs. constraint

Read the following quote by Herukhuti (Sharif Williams, PhD, MEd), known as Dr. Herukhuti. Watch the video [Race. Resistance. Love.: A Radical Reading and Discussion by Herukhuti](#) to dig deeper into Dr Herukhuti's ideas.

"If you love a person, you are a lover, if you love people, you are a revolutionary."



[1] H. "Herukhuti" Sharif Williams, PhD, MEd, known as Dr. Herukhuti, is a cultural studies scholar, sex researcher-educator, systems theorist, cultural worker (i.e., filmmaker, playwright, poet, and performance artist), interdisciplinary sociocultural scientist, and hem netcher tepi (priest-conjurer-healer in the Kemetic/Ancient Egyptian tradition) whose work operates at the intersection of race, culture, sexuality and spirituality. They are of Akan and Lissongo genetic ancestry. A bodeme (community healer and peacemaker in the Dagara tradition), Dr. Herukhuti uses a mix of pronouns. She draws upon the arts, social sciences, performance studies, and cultural studies in his research—using a variety of methods including narrative/storytelling, autoethnography, close readings of media, literary criticism, Theatre of the Oppressed, oral history interviewing and critical theory.

Information from the [Center for Culture, Sexuality and Spirituality LLC](#)

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1.3: Getting Started--What is Sociology?--Homework

The sciences have been divided into the natural and the social. What divides them? The *natural sciences* represent a branch of science concerned with the description, understanding and prediction of natural phenomena, based on empirical evidence from observation and experimentation and includes physics, chemistry and biology. The *social sciences* represent a branch of science that examines human behavior in its social and cultural aspects, from small scale groups such as the family and peer groups to medium scale institutions like corporations and educational institutions to macro level institutions such as religion, racialized and gendered systems. These includes sociology, anthropology, psychology, economics, history and political science and geography.

Before starting this activity let's take a moment to understand what a makes a question biased and to define the concept of Eurocentricism.

1) Biased Questions: Here are a few examples

It is important to focus on how we ask questions when conducting sociological research (really any type of research). Below is a list of ways in which research questions can be biased:

a) Leading questions = this is when the questions implies or encourages a particular answer.

example: Why do people prefer urban areas over rural areas? This implies the person is angry and they must answer why they are angry. We should not assume a person's emotional state.

b) Loaded or emotional language = This is when the language is strongly negative or positive.

examples: Why are video games so harmful to youth?

c) Framing bias = the way the question is framed influences how respondents will interpret it.

example: How can we ensure AI is not used in the classroom?

d) Binary bias = the question only provides respondents with two answer choices.

Do you think video games are good or bad for mental health?

e) Qualifying bias = this is a linguistic device that subtly gives preference to or constructs one category as the standard.

When my cousin had a brain injury we saw a female neuroscientist This implies that female is the non standard category.

2) What is Eurocentrism?

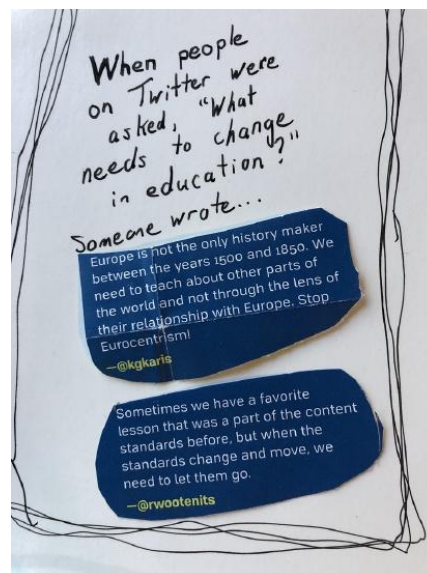
Eurocentrism is positioning European or Western culture as the standard by which to define all other cultures. This perspective views The West (which includes the United States) as the center of history, progress, knowledge and values. This in turn minimizes the contributions of other cultures and marginalizes entire groups of people, their ways of life, knowledge systems and values.

Now you are ready to do the homework assignment.

Read the assigned interview excerpt (below) and answer the following 3 questions:

1. How might the framing of the question itself be biased or reflect certain assumptions?
2. What is the stated difference between the social and natural sciences?
3. In what ways does the answer reflect a Eurocentric perspective?

Warburton: Is there something distinctive about being a social scientist, as opposed to being a scientist, or a philosopher?



Haidt: The natural sciences form the prototype of what we think the sciences are. If you're studying rocks or quarks, and there's this definitive experiment, and you design this experiment and get the results, it's very clear, it's easy to understand. But rocks and quarks do exactly what the laws of physics tell them to. The social sciences are necessary because our subjects have these properties of consciousness and intentionality. There are these emergent properties that rocks and quarks don't have. Studying people and social systems requires a different set of tools and different ways of thinking, and you can't avoid questions of meaning. For the natural sciences, meaning is not a relevant concept, but it is unavoidable in the social sciences.

Jonathan Haidt is a social psychologist and professor of ethical leadership at New York University's Stern School of Business. He is author of *The Happiness Hypothesis* and *The Righteous Mind* and is currently writing a book about morality and capitalism.

Rubric (12 points total)

Criteria	Excellent (3-4 pts)	Satisfactory (2-3 pts)	Needs Improvement (0-1 pts)
Question Bias Analysis (4 pts)	Thoughtfully identifies underlying assumptions, cultural framing, or implied value judgments in the question itself. Provides a clear example or reasoning.	Identifies some bias or assumption but with limited explanation or example.	Fails to identify or explain any assumptions or biases in the question.
Difference Between Social & Natural Sciences (3 pts)	Clearly and accurately explains the distinction as presented in the text, noting areas of overlap or complexity if applicable.	Summarizes the difference with minor inaccuracies or lacks detail.	Misunderstands or omits key distinctions between the disciplines.
Eurocentric Perspective Analysis (3 pts)	Insightfully explains how the answer reflects Eurocentric ideas (e.g., privileging Western epistemologies, excluding other worldviews, etc.) with a specific example from the text.	Mentions Eurocentrism but lacks clarity, specificity, or depth in explanation.	Does not address or misinterprets the Eurocentric aspect of the response.

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

2: The Sociological Imagination



In this module we will explore the work of C. Wright Mills (1916–1962) and his important and lasting contribution to the field of sociology. Mills was an American sociologist best known for his concept, the "sociological imagination," which describes a vision or a lens through which we can see the connection between the problems of individuals to that of broader society. You will engage with this idea by doing a classroom activity in which you will analyze different social issues using the Sociological Imagination. Finally you will complete an assignment in which you will watch a video that uses the Sociological Imagination to analyze coffee and then do your own analysis of an object.

Mills argues that we should understand personal issues in the context of the broader social world. He famously said, "Neither the life of an individual nor the history of a society can be understood without understanding both." Personal problems like unemployment, eating disorders or alcoholism can be understood by looking at larger social forces such as the economic system, war and beauty culture. Mills' book, *The Power Elite* (1956), examined the concentration of power in the hands of a few elites in the military, corporate, and political spheres. His work continues to influence sociological thought and activism. Mills believed that American society suffered from the fundamental problems of alienation, moral insensibility, threats to democracy, threats to human freedom, and conflict between bureaucratic rationality and human reason, and that the development of the sociological imagination could counter these. While many of his contemporaries focused on larger social systems, such as the structural functionalists, Mills argued that solely focusing on the macro level ignored the role of the individual. He saw the social and the individual in a dynamic relationship, which asks us to distance ourselves from our personal circumstances and view social issues in a broader context. While there is always agency in structure; seeing both gives us a more complex understanding of human behavior and personal lives.

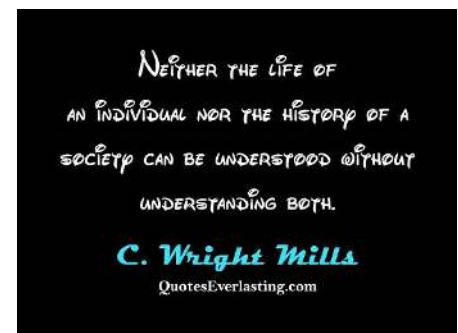
References

Mills, C. W. (1956). *The Power Elite*. Oxford University Press.

[2.1: Readings](#)

[2.2: Classroom Activity](#)

[2.3: Homework](#)



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2.1: Readings

1) Read [C Wright Mills chapter one of the Sociological Imagination, The Promise](#) (1959). In this chapter Mills outlines his concept, the Sociological Imagination and provides a number of examples. Make sure to focus on how our private lives, in which we can often feel alone and isolated, are connected to public issues, including the particular moment in history. Mills highlights how our own circumstances can make us feel like failures, yet we must also see how our lives are influenced by the society in which we live.



2) Watch this [Crash Course video](#), which will provide examples of how we can use the Sociological Imagination to analyze the following:

Social class

Gender and power

Social class

Race and racism

Globalization

Crime and deviance

Education religion

Family and marriage

Health and illness

Technology

Political issues

References

Mills, C. W. (1959). The promise. *The sociological imagination*, 3-24.

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2.2: Classroom Activity

Below are different pairs of words used to refer to the two levels private vs public used in the *sociological imagination*

Individual ----- Society

Personal/Private----- Public

Micro ----- Macro

Biography ----- History

Mills uses Personal/Public ----- Public and Biography ----- History most often.

Now it's time to put the *sociological imagination* into practice. Below are a series of scenarios. The class can be broken into 7 groups with each group assigned one scenario and then share with the whole class or the class can go through each scenario together. For each scenario discuss how you could explain this personal issue by relating it to larger social factors.



- SOMEONE HAS AN EATING DISORDER**
- SOMEONE LOSES THEIR JOB**
- SOMEONE GETS A DIVORCE**
- SOMEONE BECOMES HOMELESS**
- SOMEONE IS ADDICTED TO DRUGS**
- SOMEONE'S CAR GETS BOOTED**
- SOMEONE GET'S THEIR DREAM JOB**

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2.3: Homework

For this analysis you will be writing up a sociological analysis of a object following the analysis you will watch in the following video.

Sociology of Coffee video by Professor Ben Cushing.

1) Discuss how Professor Cushing analyzes coffee from the following topic angles. Separate your answers into paragraphs by topic.

- 1) Norms / deviance
- 2) Cultural rituals
- 3) Symbolism/class/privilege
- 4) Colonialism
- 5) Global economy
- 6) Social relations

2) Now analyze coffee from the following topic angles, which are not discussed in the video.

- 7) Gender
- 8) Race

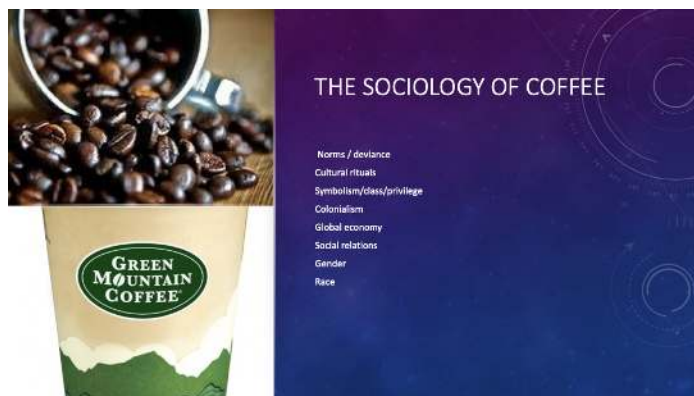
3) Finally choose an object from the following list and analyze it using the 8 topic angles from above.

- Toilet paper
- Soap
- Bicycle
- Camera
- Tattoo
- Perfume/Cologne

3) You should have a total of 16 short paragraphs.

RUBRIC (Total: 80 points)

Each of the four criteria is worth 5 points. Students address all 8 topics in structured paragraphs.



Criterion	5 – Excellent	3–4 – Proficient	1–2 – Needs Improvement
Depth of Sociological Analysis	Insightful, nuanced treatment across all topics (e.g., colonialism, gender, race); strong sociological terminology	Covers most topics with adequate analysis; some sociological terms used	Superficial mentions, missing key topics or terminology
Use of Evidence & Examples	Specific, relevant examples connecting video and chosen object; draws from multiple sources or perspectives.	Some specific examples; uses a few perspectives to discuss each topic	Vague or generic examples; little connection to topics or evidence
Structure & Argument Coherence	Each paragraph clearly organized, with topic sentence and cohesive argument	Paragraphs generally clear, may lack transitions or depth	Disorganized paragraphs, unclear or absent topic focus
Writing Mechanics & Style	Fluent, polished writing with proper grammar, minimal errors	Generally clear writing with minor errors	Frequent errors that impede clarity

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

3: Sociological Theories

The term sociology was first coined in 1780 by the French essayist Emmanuel-Joseph Sieyès (1748–1836) in an unpublished manuscript (Fauré et al. 1999). In 1838, the term was reintroduced by Auguste Comte (1798–1857) who is most often credited with introducing the academic discipline of sociology.

In this module we will explore key terms such as *positivism* and *anti-positivism*, after which you will demonstrate your understanding by sharing ideas about both. You will engage with the key theories that arose in the West as frameworks for understanding the social world and human behavior. You will learn about two sociological theories that arose in Europe in the 19th century: *Structural functionalism* and *Conflict Theory*, and one theory that developed in the United States in the mid 20th century, *Symbolic Interactionism*. We will also explore Social Constructionism, which most often is not included as one of the sociological theories. We will explore it as an influential perspective that has many similarities to Symbolic Interactionism. These are the theories that arose in the West, at a particular historical moment and developed by individuals of a particular social status, as frameworks for understanding the social world and human behavior. The module ends with an assignment in which you will apply these theories to understandings of the police. In module 4 we will explore ideas from social thinkers from other parts of the world



whose ideas arose in different time periods.

References

Fauré, Christine, Jacques Guilhaumou, Jacques Vallier, and Françoise Weil. 2007 [1999]. *Des Manuscrits de Sieyès, 1773–1799*, Volumes I and II. Paris: Champion.

[3.1: Readings](#)

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3.1: Readings

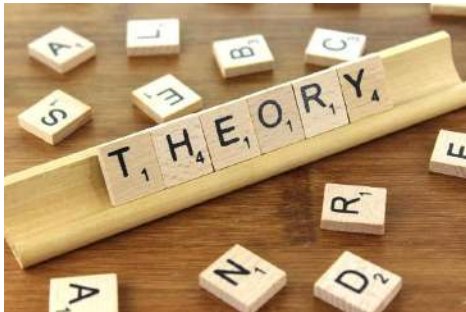
A) Positivism and Anti Positivism

Comte emphasized the scientific study of society, using methods that replicated those of the natural sciences, with the goal of uncovering “social facts.” He also introduced the idea of *positivism* into the social sciences. Watch the two videos below on *positivism* and *anti-Positivism*.

1) Watch this video on [positivism](#), which details Comte's idea of positivism and how it guides sociological inquiry. It details positivism as a scientific and systematic approach, emphasizing empirical observation and the experimental method. These guiding principles for sociological inquiry aimed to overcome metaphysical and religious explanations and uncover social and behavioral regularities. Comte believed there are stages of societal development; The theological, metaphysical and the positivist. Positivism's goal is to identify both social statics and social dynamics.

2) Watch this video on [anti-positivism](#), introduced in the late 19th and early 20th century. It outlines the key proponents, Wilhelm Dilthey, Heinrich Rickert, Max Weber, Thomas Kuhn and Talcott Parsons. The anti-positivism movement introduced humanistic sociology or interpretivist sociology.

B) The Sociological Theories



Below is a brief definition of the 3 major sociological theories; *Structural Functionalism*, *Conflict Theory* and *Symbolic Interactionism*

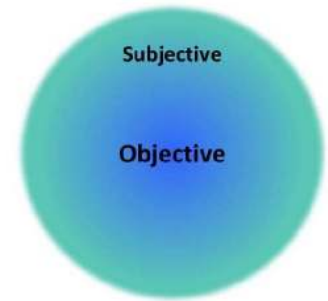
Structural Functionalism (macro-level analysis): Sees society as interrelated parts or structures (social institutions) and focuses on social stability. When instability occurs, institutions must adjust to reestablish social order and harmony.

Conflict Theory (macro-level analysis)- Sees society as characterized by inequality and power dynamics and challenge the status quo and encourages social change in order to equitize these power imbalances.

Symbolic Interactionism (micro-level analysis)—sees society as meaning making that occurs through social interaction. Meanings is fluid in that it can vary over time and from group to group.

Social Constructionism is most often not included as one of the sociological theories, yet it is an influential set of ideas about the social world that has many common assumptions to Symbolic Interactionism. In their pinnacle book, *The Social Construction of Reality* (1966), Berger and Luckmann argue these points:

- Categories are not innate or inherent to objects or ideas; people create categories and concepts which shape (construct) reality
- People develop knowledge of the world in a social context and that much of what we perceive as reality depends on shared assumptions
- Knowledge is socially constructed – knowledge arises out of human relationship. What we take to be true and objective arises in cultural and historical contexts
- Language is central to social constructionism...language is not neutral; it is rule-governed, and it places parameters around what we can and do know (Sapir Whorf Hypothesis)
- Knowledge construction is politically driven



Now watch this [CrashCourse video](#), which defines the idea of a theoretical paradigms (this is another way to say theories), looks at micro macro level analysis, and explores the three major paradigms : *Structural Functionalism*, *Conflict Theory* and *Symbolic Interactionism*.

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3.2: Classroom Activity

After exploring the ideas of *positivism* and *anti-positivism* you will now debate these viewpoints.

The class is divided into two groups, one is assigned positivism and the other anti-positivism.



Get into your group and discuss the main ideas of the viewpoint you are assigned.

Develop an argument for why this is this viewpoint should be followed in sociological inquiry. Review the ideas of the key proponents of your viewpoint as group members can take on their roles. Remember different proponents within the same viewpoint hold slightly different ideas and beliefs.

Create a platform for debate by prompting with one or many of the following questions and have the two groups debate.

1. Why is your viewpoint the one that should be the guiding principle for sociological inquiry?
2. How do you interpret and argue the possibility (or lack thereof) of objectivity in sociological inquiry?
3. Is understanding meaning important in sociological research? Why or Why not?
4. Let's go with meaning is important how can researchers get at meaning using either of the two viewpoints?
5. Not yet having this knowledge from our course do you believe that the historical development of sociology makes one of these viewpoints more relevant? Why?

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3.3: Homework

The homework assignment is to write an essay (30 points) in which you apply the three sociological theories; Structural Functionalism, Conflict Theory and Symbolic Interactionism.

Write at least a paragraph for each theory that details how someone from that theoretical perspective would understand and analyze the police.

This can include explaining why the police exist and how they operate in society.



RUBRIC (total 36 points)

Criteria	Structural Functionalism (10 pts)	Conflict Theory (10 pts)	Symbolic Interactionism (10 pts)
Thesis & Theory Explanation (4 pts)	States that policing enforces social norms, maintains order, promotes cohesion and manages dysfunction. (Macro focus)	- Frames police as tools of power serving elite interests. - Mentions class conflict, resource control, inequality (macro level).	- Highlights importance of symbols (badges, uniforms), labeling, meaning in policing. - Connects micro-level interactions to identity & perception.
Depth of Concept Use (4 pts)	Applies: manifest/latent functions, social cohesion, dysfunctions.	Uses: power dynamics, inequality, oppression, class struggle.	Uses: symbols, meaning-making, labeling, self-fulfilling prophecy.
Examples & Analysis (2 pts)	e.g., enforcing traffic laws (manifest); over-policing erodes trust (latent dysfunction).	e.g., racial profiling, protecting elite interests, reproducing inequality.	e.g., badge/uniform shaping trust/fear, body cam interactions, meaning in traffic stops.
Writing Quality & Structure (evaluative across all) (2 pts)	Coherent, well-structured writing with clear transitions and minimal errors.	—	—

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